pleasure and also on the children," says the CBI chargesheet. All of this was filmed...remember that pen drive cache? During interrogation, Rambhawan also confessed he used to share the fruits of his labour "on Gmail and cloud-based data storage services like Mega.nz, Box.com etc".

Most of all, these lone ravening wolves hunted in sheep's clothing. As a young scholarly figure, Victor was trusted and liked in the neighbourhood. No parent thought twice about children going to his house. Small amounts of money, chocolate and toffee paved their little highways to hell. His known tally: five children from his neighbourhood. The youngest was a five-year-old; the oldest just under 18. The other three were 16, nine and eight—the last, a girl from his immediate family for whom Victor was an uncle, had lived as his victim since she was six. In fact, all had spent the last few years in that black zone. He would force each one to bring friends to him, force them into sexual activities with each other, and force himself on them successively—making the other watch all the time, and with his phone cam whirring away in one hand. Thus, besides securing immediate gratification, he built up a stockpile of photos and videos that he could revisit at leisure, or wield as weapons against the children, and also turn into commodities on the nether zones of a world connected by ether. But it was the Google notification that led the CBI to him.

IF CHILD PORN HAS BECOME A DIGITALLY AMPLIFIED FORCE UNTO ITSELF, DETECTION TOO IS HOT ON ITS HEELS. THE NEW WORLD DEMANDS CONSTANT VIGIL ON A RANGE OF DIGITAL PATHWAYS

THE DIGITAL FORENSICS

Where the game of detection enters a higher realm is when the digital material itself provides the lead. Tracing Rambhawan's faceless victims from among the teeming millions of mofussil UP was like looking for a needle in a haystack—plenty of old-style grunt work was called for. This is how it goes. In a blind case, investigators first try to parse any language or dialect that crops up in the video. Then they spend hours and days minutely examining objects in the video. All of this feeds a larger cyber forensic analysis. For example, the CBI recently received, through Interpol, images showing a minor girl being subjected to sexual abuse. Analysis with advanced cyber forensic tools revealed the precise GPS coordinates of the scene of the crime, as well as its date and time. This is nothing less than a miracle—in layman's terms, with just a digital image of a crime, the CBI is getting to within 10 metres of where it happened. Based on the image data, the CBI identified the victim and was later able to nab the offender, one Ravi Kumar Patel. He was found to be the admin of a WhatsApp group with several Indian and foreign members, where he shared self-produced CSAM. The info was duly passed on to 26 countries. A parallel technique is to follow the digital slipstream—going through metadata and OSINT (Open Source Intelligence) tools to prise open a video's secrets. The biggest success here for the CBI, one that won it global plaudits, was a hunt they nicknamed Operation Megh Chakra (see *Crime and Punishment*).

If crime has become a digitally amplified force unto itself, detection too is hot on its heels. The new world demands constant surveillance of a range of digital pathways: suspect transactions via cryptocurrencies or mobile wallets like PayPal, messaging services like WhatsApp, Telegram, IMO and Viber, livestreaming applications like SPlayer and MXPlayer, and cloud services like pdisk, xdisk, mdisk and Mega.nz. Not to even speak of the dark web. But amidst all this disorienting technology, the human factor endures: the vulnerable child, perhaps scarred for life, and the one who predates. Dr Sudhir Gupta, the one who conducted a psychological test on Rambhawan, said, "Social deviants like him never believe what they were doing is a crime. He was highly non-cooperative. People like Rambhawan can never be treated and it's best to keep them behind bars always."

But the CBI has to overcome several procedural hurdles to bring these offenders to book. The online CSAM cases are registered under Sections 67B of the Information Technology (IT) Act and Sections 14/15 of the PoCSO Act besides Section 293 of the Indian Penal Code (see *Crime and Punishment*). But only about 10 states have given their general consent to the CBI to probe cases under the IT Act. None has given it for cases under the PoCSO Act. It means, in the absence of general consent, the central agency has to seek case-by-case approval from states to lodge an FIR, which is time-consuming and delays the investigation. When it comes to prosecution, another key challenge is to prove the veracity of the CSAM. Under the Indian Evidence Act, any secondary electronic evidence must accompany a '65B certificate'—named after the section of the Act under which it finds mention. But getting this certificate from foreign-based Internet Service Providers and social media platforms, let alone ensuring their representatives are present in person to verify the authenticity of material, is a headache. But despite these difficulties, the CBI is now building sufficient tools and evidence to ensure that child predators like Gupta, Victor and Rambhawan get caught and punished for their heinous crimes. ■

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